

Hengan (1044.HK, NC): APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day 2026

Takeaways: Still intense pricing competition; maintained SD% FY sales

APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day
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Bottom line: We hosted Hengan's (not covered) mgmt at our APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day event on Jul 2nd and 3rd. Mgmt acknowledged limited improvement in terms of pricing competition for Tissue and Sanitary napkins in 1H26, where Tissue sales declined by MSD%-HSD% yoy in 5M26 and Sanitary napkin sales were broadly flattish. The company will continue to prioritize profitability, brand equity and premium positioning over defending volume through price cuts. Mgmt maintained its FY26 target of SD% yoy sales growth for tissue, driven by wet wipe (up by HSD% in 5M26), more effective advertising and brand positioning. The company also targets SD% growth in sanitary napkin although the market competition landscape remains fragmented and intense. On cost outlook, mgmt expects 1H26 **GPM** to remain broadly stable yoy for both Tissue and Sanitary napkin. Some pressure from oil-linked raw materials will begin to appear from Jun and 3Q GPM may be slightly pressured though mgmt considers the impact manageable and the company does not plan to raise prices.

The authors would like to thank Lily Qi for her contribution to this report.

Key Takeaways

By segment update

- **Tissue** sales declined by MSD%-HSD% yoy in 5M26, with **dry tissue** (c.50% of total tissue revenue) remaining the biggest drag due to intensive pricing competition. Mgmt noted competition became meaningfully more intense during 2Q26, the company chose not to follow price cuts in order to protect margins and brand positioning. **Wet wipe** continued to outperform with HSD% growth in 5M26 with higher profitability despite a small scale. The company still targets tissue to achieve SD% growth for FY26, driven by brand positioning and product differentiation.
- **Sanitary napkin** sales were broadly flattish in 5M26. Mgmt commented on fragmented industry competition with limited improvement in market structure,

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but believes Hengan remains one of the leading brands with better product quality. The strategy remains focused on premiumization and younger consumers, rather than competing on price, per mgmt.

- **Diapers** continued to underperform, declining HSD%. GPM remained broadly stable, with the sanitary napkin & diaper segment maintaining approximately 60% GPM.

Cost outlook:

Mgmt expects 1H26 **GPM** to remain broadly stable yoy for both Tissue and Sanitary napkin. Wood pulp prices have remained relatively stable and are expected to stay benign in 2H26 as domestic supply increases. Some pressure from oil-linked raw materials will begin to appear from Jun and 3Q GPM may be slightly pressured while mgmt considers the impact manageable and the company does not plan to raise prices.

Sales expenses remains broadly similar to 2H25 in absolute terms, with increasing emphasis on more efficient, ROI-focused advertising.

Other key updates

FX: Around Rmb100mn FX loss in 5M26 vs. FX gains previously, representing an additional earnings headwind.

Government subsidies: Mgmt mentioned likely lower government subsidies vs. 2025 and noted the trend will likely persist in the future.

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